

The Noble Inquiry of Anavatapta, King of the Nāgas: A Dhāraṇī

Āryatapasvī Nāgarāja Paripṛcchā Nāma Dhāraṇī · Toh 659 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་དང་སངས་ལ་བློ་པའི་གློ་པོ་ཞུ་བ་ཞེས་བ་བྱའུ་གི་བུ་སྒྲུ་ལ།

Toh 659 in the Kangyur is a dhāraṇī sūtra known in Sanskrit as the Āryatapasvī Nāgarāja Paripṛcchā Nāma Dhāraṇī and in Tibetan as the dhāraṇī called "The Noble Inquiry of Anavatapta, King of the Nāgas." It belongs to the general class of Mahāyāna sūtras and takes the form of a teaching given by the Buddha at Gṛdhrakūṭa Mountain in Magadha, prompted by a visit from Anavatapta, the luminous nāga king, who comes to question the Blessed One. The text thus combines the sūtra and dhāraṇī genres, presenting both a narrative framing dialogue and a sacred spell or formula associated with the nāga king's inquiry. It was translated into Tibetan by the Indian preceptors Jinamitra and Surendrabodhi together with the great revising translator, the monk Yeshé Dé, and established in its final form through their collaborative editorial process.

Thus is completed the Great Vehicle sūtra called the Heart Essence.

Translated and edited by the Indian preceptors Jinamitra and Surendrabodhi, together with the great revising translator, the monk Yeshé Dé, and established in final form.

In the language of India: Āryatapasvī Nāgarāja Paripṛcchā Nāma Dhāraṇī. In the Tibetan language: The dhāraṇī called "The Noble Inquiry of Anavatapta, King of the Nāgas."

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear. At one time the Blessed One was dwelling in the region of Magadha, in Indra's Grotto on Gṛdhrakūṭa Mountain. Then the nāga king Anavatapta, of supremely resplendent complexion, rose at dawn and went to where the Blessed One was. Having arrived, he bowed his head to the feet of the Blessed One and addressed him thus: "Blessed One, for a long time this Gṛdhrakūṭa Mountain has harmed the monks. How may I ensure that they are no longer harmed?" When he had spoken these words, the Blessed One declared to the nāga king Anavatapta: "Excellent! Excellent, O Nāga King! This is indeed what you should do."

Then the Blessed One addressed the monks: "Monks, therefore retain the names of these eighteen great medicines and poisons. Thus: Paṇḍare, Karaṇḍa,

Keyūre, Bodhyaṃgamate, Bindumate, Araḍa, Taraḍa, Taruḍa, Dahadahana, Etadaha, Jeleje la, Phale, Śataśata, Kulenakuli, Ekarṣitaradgapṛṣṭhi. Monks, in the body of anyone who retains the names of these eighteen great medicines and poisons, epidemic disease will find no foothold. Poison, weapons, sorcery, reanimated corpses, and fevers lasting one day, two days, three days, or four days will find no foothold. Serpents will no longer be able to harm them. Anyone who holds these names will be protected for as long as they live."

When the Blessed One had declared this, the nāga king Anavatapta was filled with joy and rejoiced in the words of the Blessed One.

Thus is completed the dhāraṇī called "The Noble Inquiry of Anavatapta, King of the Nāgas."

Translator's Notes

- The text opens with the colophon of one sūtra and then moves immediately into a second, independent text, the Anavatapta Nāgarāja Paripṛcchā Dhāraṇī, which has its own Sanskrit title, Tibetan title, and colophon. The transition is abrupt in the original and is faithfully rendered here without editorial smoothing.

The name rendered "Anavatapta" translates the Tibetan "gzi can," literally "the lustrous one" or "the one endowed with brilliance." Anavatapta is the standard Sanskrit identification of this celebrated nāga king, whose name means "the unheated" or "the cool one" and who dwells in a famous cool lake. The Tibetan epithet "gzi can" reflects a distinct attribute, but the being intended is unambiguously Anavatapta as confirmed by the Sanskrit title.

The dhāraṇī syllables are given as they stand in the Tibetan transliteration; no attempt is made to normalize them, as the Indic forms in this transmission are liturgically fixed. The phrase rendered "reanimated corpses" translates a term for zombies or animated corpses in the protective-charm literature.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.